

About the Canadiana Collection

The Canadiana Collection is a trusted resource containing approximately 31.5 million pages of historical publications from c. 1500 to the present day. This collection includes books, newspapers, magazines, government documents, maps, and more.

Discover digitized publications

Browse materials spanning approximately five centuries of Canadian writing and publishing

A trusted resource for nearly 50 years

The Canadiana Collections and Infrastructure have grown alongside generations of researchers, continually expanding, modernizing, and adapting to new ways of working with knowledge. All materials in the collections are digitally preserved in the Canadiana Trustworthy Digital Repository, ensuring their long-term security.

What you can find in the Canadiana Collection

Books and Publications

This collection brings together books and pamphlets that document centuries of Canadian print culture, supporting research in history, literature, politics, religion, science, and everyday life. Titles were selected and digitized from more than 200 libraries and archives, and the collection includes both well-known works and rarer items identified through surveys of special collections and uncatalogued holdings.

98,000+ titles

Coverage to c. 1920

45+ languages

Highlights:

- Works covering Indigenous history and languages, such as [New familiar Abenakis and English dialogues](#) by Joseph Laurent (Sozap Lolô)
- Works by 19th century Canadian authors, such as [Anne of Green Gables](#) by Lucy Maud Montgomery
- Works by visitors about the lands we now know as Canada, such as [American Notes for General Circulation](#) by Charles Dickens

Newspapers and Magazines

This collection preserves newspapers, magazines, and other serial publications that show how Canadians built communities, discussed events, and represented everyday life. It is valuable for formal research, but also easy to use for readers exploring public opinion, popular culture, and local history.

1,700+ periodical titles
Coverage to the 21st century

Highlights:

- Community newspapers in different languages, such as the [Chinese Times](#)
- Specialized periodicals covering literature, science, politics, religion, sport, and more, such as [Science Dimension](#)
- City directories and annual reports, such as [Minutes of the African Baptist Association of Nova Scotia](#)
- Popular consumer magazines, such as [La Revue Populaire](#)

Government Publications

This collection gathers official publications that show how government bodies recorded decisions, administered policy, and defined public life in Canada before 1900. It gives researchers and students direct access to the documentary record of law, governance, and administration.

8,500+ books and publications
79 series titles

Pre-1900 focus

Highlights:

- Parliamentary publications from 1867–1900, such as [Official report of the debates of the House of Commons of the Dominion of Canada](#)
- Governmental reports on Canadian science and industry, such as [Forest protection in Canada, 1912](#)
- Pre-Confederation government publications, such as [The provincial statutes of Lower-Canada](#)

Maps

The Maps collection offers nearly 22,000 digitized Canadian maps from the 1:50,000 scale National Topographic Series. It supports spatial and environmental research, while also helping non-specialists visualize how places, boundaries, and infrastructure changed over time. The maps were digitized by [McGill University Library](#) and shared through a partnership with [CRKN](#), marking the first major addition of member-contributed content to the Canadiana collection.

Approximately 22,000 maps
1905 to 2012
National Topographic Series 1:50,000

Highlights:

- Detailed maps of Canada's thirteen provinces and territories
- Parts of the series are also available through Scholars GeoPortal and Borealis, where georeferenced versions support open geospatial research and historical analysis

How to Use Canadiana

1. **Start broad:** Use Basic Search to identify promising records, then narrow with filters for monographs (for books and publications), serials (for newspapers and magazines), maps, or government publications.
2. **Refine queries:** Apply methods from [Navigating the Collections](#), including exact phrases in quotes and operators like `?`, `*`, `-`, and `|`.
3. **Save evidence:** When relevant records appear, download them with the **IMG**, **PAGE**, and **FULL** options (if available), then copy the persistent URL.
4. **Cite correctly:** Follow the [Citation Guide](#), cite Canadiana as the source, and include the persistent URL.

FAQ

What time period does the Canadiana Collection cover?

The collection includes materials from roughly 1500 to the present day, with especially strong coverage of pre-Confederation and early modern publication history.

How were materials selected for digitization?

Selection was guided by collection specialists and scholars, with emphasis on Canadian imprints, high-use historical sources, and materials that support broad interdisciplinary study.

Can I search inside documents?

Yes. Full-text and metadata search are available where text extraction exists, alongside title, creator, and subject searching.

Is this collection suitable for teaching as well as research?

Yes. The range of formats and topics supports undergraduate instruction, graduate seminars, and advanced scholarly projects. The collection also includes content that supports exposure to primary source materials for high school students.